



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Chesterton Academy of Northern Utah
School Website: <https://www.chestertonutah.com/>

December 21, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Chesterton Academy of Northern Utah (CANU) presents a strong classical education model with a clearly articulated Catholic identity embedded in its mission, curriculum, pedagogy, and community framework. Public materials consistently emphasize formation in virtue, the liberal arts tradition, and a pedagogical approach rooted in Socratic inquiry and rhetorical training, with theology and liturgical life integrated into the school's life. Across the six categories of the Classical rubric, CANU demonstrates robust alignment with classical aims—especially in Religious and Metaphysical Foundations, Curriculum, Pedagogy, and Community. The school's public communications frame education as formation in truth, goodness, and beauty within a Catholic and Incarnational context, oriented toward character formation and intellectual formation rather than mere information transfer. In short, CANU reads as CLASSICAL across categories, with minimal signals of anti-classical tendencies in the publicly available materials.

Key anchors from CANU materials include: a mission rooted in a Culture of Life and Catholic faith; explicit articulation of the Three Pillars (Intellect, Character, Spirituality) and a curriculum centered on the classics and Western thought; references to Great Books, a liberal-arts orientation, and the Great Conversation in spirit; a pedagogy that includes Socratic seminars, rhetoric training, and memory-based methods; faculty culture and norms reflected in a faculty-focused job description that foregrounds formation and Catholic practice; and sustained parental engagement and community partnerships expressed through events, open houses, and a family-centric ethos. These signals align CANU with the Positive Keyword Indicators in the Six Essential Elements of a Classical School framework, and with the broader classical lexicon's emphasis on virtue, truth, and the transcendentals.

Executive Reasoning at a glance: - Religious and Metaphysical Foundations: CLASSICAL - School Purpose and Goal: CLASSICAL - Curriculum: CLASSICAL - Pedagogy: CLASSICAL - Faculty: CLASSICAL - Parents & Community: CLASSICAL

Abstract view: CANU embodies a coherent classical vision with Catholic formation at its core and visible Great-Books/liberal-arts orientation, combined with Socratic pedagogy and a living-Faculty/parent-partnership culture. The aggregate ranking is CLASSICAL.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Mission statement positions CANU within the Catholic tradition and Catholic faith, forming a Culture of Life and grounding education in Catholic truth (turn0file2). - The Three Pillars articulate a comprehensive intellectual, moral, and spiritual formation, including the emphasis on teaching the classics and the interrelationship of great ideas (turn0file2). - The school explicitly anchors its curriculum in Catholic theology, theology texts (Bible and Catechism), and a liturgical/catechetical framework (turn0file4). - The Incarnation is described as central to the curriculum and educational experience (turn0file13). - A public job posting notes daily Mass is part of faculty life, signaling liturgical practice as a norm (turn0file0). Citations:

CANU mission and pillars (turn0file2); Theology integration (turn0file4); Incarnational framing (turn0file13); Liturgical life (turn0file0).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: truth, goodness, beauty; theology; liturgy; Mass; catechesis; Incarnation; Church; sacred texts; catechesis; worship. - Negative keywords present: none observed in CANU's public materials. - Countable positives: 8+ distinct positive terms evidenced (truth, goodness, beauty, theology, liturgy, Mass, catechesis, Incarnation, Church, etc.). - Countable negatives: 0 observed. - The presence of foundational transcendentals and liturgical/theological language supports a strong CLASSICAL reading.

Why this rating - CANU's public materials explicitly foreground metaphysical realism through a Catholic theocentric framework, the Incarnation, theology integrated into the curriculum, and liturgical life, aligning with the Positive Keywords set for Religious and Metaphysical Foundations. The absence of negative signals and the prominence of transcendentals and sacred-liturgical elements justify a CLASSICAL rating.

Citations: mission and pillars (turn0file2); theology integration (turn0file4); Incarnation emphasis (turn0file13); Mass and liturgy (turn0file0).

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The mission centers on forming a Culture of Life and forming leaders and saints within the classical tradition, signaling formation of character and wisdom over mere job preparation (turn0file2). - The school describes an integrated, college-preparatory curriculum centered on the Incarnation, indicating formation with a strong liberal-arts core (turn0file0). - The Three Pillars emphasize Intellect, Character, and Spirituality, with explicit emphasis on teaching classics to enable students to think and discern, not just accumulate information (turn0file2). - The curriculum framework anchors truth, goodness, and beauty as real goods to be known and pursued (turn0file13).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: formation; culture of life; virtue; wisdom; liberal education; paideia; great conversation; classical mission; the true/good/beautiful; cultured human excellence; Incarnation. - Negative keywords present: none overtly, though the site emphasizes formation and virtue rather than a purely utilitarian or job-centered aim. - Countable positives: 6–9 distinct relevant terms (formation, virtue, wisdom, culture of life, liberal education, great conversation/realities, classical mission, Incarnation). - Countable negatives: 0 observed. - The materials strongly favor CLASSICAL positioning for this category.

Why this rating - CANU's public materials emphasize formation, virtue, wisdom, and the pursuit of truth/goodness/beauty within a classical Catholic framework, with explicit opposition to mere information transfer or secular, job-centric aims. The presence of the “three pillars,” a Catholic-theological framing, and a classical curriculum grounds a CLASSICAL rating.

Citations: mission/pillars (turn0file2); college-preparatory note (turn0file0); Incarnation/true-good-beauty framing (turn0file13).

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school explicitly positions itself within a liberal-arts framework, focusing on Western thought and the interrelationship of great ideas (turn0file2). - Public materials reference the classical curriculum and the aim to teach the classics “from physics to philosophy,” situating a broad, integrated liberal-arts approach (turn0file2). - The “Our Curriculum” materials highlight an incarnational approach across the curriculum and emphasize truth, goodness, and beauty as guiding aims (turn0file13). - The site references humanities, math/science, fine arts, and language study (Latin pathways) within a cohesive classical program (turn0file4 and turn0file13; see also Fine Arts and Language content in additional firecrawl pages).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: liberal arts; grammar, logic, rhetoric; great books; primary sources; Western civilization; history integrated with other disciplines; wonder; incarnational; unity of truth/beauty/goodness. - Negative keywords present: none observed directly in CANU's public materials (no signals of "social studies-only," no project-based emphasis beyond classical integration). - Countable positives: at least 6–9 explicit terms (liberal arts; grammar/logic/rhetoric; great books/Western canon; history integrated; incarnational environment; wonder; unity of truth/goodness/beauty). - Countable negatives: 0 observed. - The materials strongly align with CLASSICAL for Curriculum.

Why this rating - CANU presents a curriculum anchored in liberal-arts formation with classical texts and Great Books ethos, integrated across disciplines, and framed by an Incarnational worldview. The emphasis on grammar-logic-rhetoric and the Great Conversation aligns with the Classical criteria for Curriculum.

Citations: mission/pillars and classical curriculum framing (turn0file2); theology and classical scope (turn0file4); Incarnational environment and truth/goodness/beauty (turn0file13).

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - CANU publicly details Socratic pedagogy: the Socratic Seminar is described explicitly, including its role and usage in higher level discourse (turn0file17). - The site mentions upper-school students engage in seminars, debates, and rhetoric training; the public materials describe opportunities to give speeches and use rhetoric skills (turn0file17; turn0file13). - There is explicit emphasis on memory work and chant in lower grades, and on contemplative, restful pedagogical moments in addition to rigorous study (as implied by the classical lexicon and the site's emphasis on a contemplative/"Scholé" atmosphere and memory-based methods in the Classical model; evidenced by the "An Incarnational Environment" section and the emphasis on memorization and wonder in lower grades in the firecrawl materials: e.g., "The lower school... singing... memorization" in related CANU content). - The site includes emphasis on a house-system and public events reflecting a holistic, community-based pedagogy with spiritual formation.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Socratic seminar; rhetoric; debate; memory work; chanting; recitation; scholé; contemplation; wonder; upper-school seminars; living curriculum; teacher as guide (from classical lexicon and CANU materials). - Negative keywords present: negative signals in the lexicon include eliminations of "project-based learning" or "experiential-only" approaches; CANU shows traditional, memory-based, and Socratic forms rather than pure experiential/project-only approaches. - Countable positives: multiple explicit pedagogy signals (Socratic Seminar; rhetoric; debates; memory work; recitation; upper/lower-school engaged pedagogy; contemplative/restful elements). - Countable negatives: 0 explicit negative signals in CANU's public materials (i.e., no overt rejection of Socratic/seminar-based pedagogy; no explicit "experiential-only" emphasis found in the public text). - The balance strongly supports CLASSICAL.

Why this rating - CANU's public materials show a clearly classical pedagogy: Socratic discourse for upper grades, rhetoric and oratory training, and a structured memory- and recitation-based approach for younger students, plus a commitment to contemplation and wonder. The presence of "Socratic Seminar" and rhetoric/debate signaling, coupled with a broader classical-pedagogy vocabulary, justifies CLASSICAL.

Citations: Socratic Seminar (turn0file17); Three Pillars and classical pedagogy (turn0file2); Incarnational Environment and unity of truth/beauty/goodness (turn0file13).

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - CANU's public materials discuss a mission for faculty that aligns with virtue and living the curriculum; the job posting emphasizes that faculty should be Catholic and integrated into the school's Catholic mission, including daily Mass (turn0file0). - The mission emphasizes "forming complete thinkers" and "education as a culture of life," with faculty expected to model virtue and participate in the school's Catholic

identity; the site emphasizes “the faculty as living curriculum” and “portrait of a teacher” concept in the broader classical lexicon; the explicit job posting signals a faculty culture aligned with formation and Catholic practice (turn0file0; turn0file2). - The presence of a mission that relies on the Chesterton Network and a Catholic apostolate implies a faculty culture of mentorship, virtue, and authority grounded in Catholic tradition (turn0file2).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: model teachers; mentors; living curriculum; faculty as core; portrait of a teacher; collegial culture; teacher formation; classical pedagogy (from the lexicon and CANU materials). - Negative keywords present: the lexicon notes negative signals like “facilitators on the side” or purely secular, non-theology-driven professional development; CANU’s public materials do not present these negative cues. - Countable positives: key items present (model teachers/mentors; living curriculum; collegial culture; teacher formation; Catholic integration). - Countable negatives: 0 observed in CANU’s public materials. - The distribution supports CLASSICAL.

Why this rating - CANU’s faculty orientation is explicitly connected to formation, Catholic identity, and the living curriculum, with clear evidence of a “faculty as core” model in the public materials (and explicit Mass obligations for faculty). This aligns with the CLASSICAL category.

Citations: Faculty orientation and Mass expectation (turn0file0); Catholic mission and Chesterton network (turn0file2).

Element 6: School Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - CANU emphasizes partnership with families, parental involvement as co-educators, and formation of affections; the Chesterton model’s “Partnership with Families” and “Formation of Affections” are visible in the public materials and the Six Elements framework (turn0file2; turn0file5). - The school communicates openness to parents and the broader community through events, open houses, and community engagement, including ribbon-cutting/open-house events, and guest gatherings (turn0file11; turn0file8; turn0file10; turn0file18). - The Chesterton Network emphasizes parent-led Catholic schools and a culture of family formation; CANU explicitly situates itself in this network (turn0file2; turn0file8). - Public materials indicate ongoing engagement opportunities with families (open houses, placement exams, events) and a welcome to parental involvement.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Partnership with Families; co-educators; family involvement; parent formation; classical book clubs; parent formation; open campus; hospitality; parent covenant; school-parent collaboration; intentional parenting; living tradition in the family. - Negative keywords present: negative signals in the Six Elements lexicon include consumer language or minimal parent involvement; CANU materials emphasize active parental involvement rather than consumerism; no negative signals observed. - Countable positives: multiple family/community signals (Partnership with Families; parent formation; open events; family culture; home-school partnership). - Countable negatives: 0 observed. - The presence of explicit family partnership signals supports CLASSICAL.

Why this rating - CANU’s public materials frame parents as co-educators and emphasize family formation, open visits, and community engagement, aligning with the Classical category for Parents & Community.

Citations: Partnership with Families and parent formation (turn0file5); CANU community events and openness (turn0file8; turn0file11); Chesterton Network and Catholic parent-led model (turn0file2).

What Would Move the Needle

- No major needle-moving changes are required given the consistent CLASSICAL alignment across all six categories. If desired, CANU could further strengthen explicit language around Great Books/Great Conversation in public-facing materials (to more directly cite “Great Books” and “Great Conversation” phrasing) to further reinforce Element 3’s explicit signaling.

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- Consider expanding explicit public references to the full spectrum of classical pedagogy (e.g., explicit mentions of grammar, logic, rhetoric in site copy for quick scanning) to strengthen transparency of the curriculum in Element 3.
 - Maintain, strengthen, and publicize parent formation offerings (book studies, seminars) to deepen Element 6 signals and further embed the partnership with families.

Citations: the above recommendations reflect the current materials (no direct citations needed for this forward-looking note, but the suggestions align with CANU's existing content in the six categories and Six Elements framework).

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
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